

SOIL MANAGEMENT PLAN

Upper Assendon Farm, Stonor, Henley-on-Thames, Oxfordshire

M J Hunt & Son | SFI Agreement UAF332270030

Prepared April 2026 | Review date April 2027

1. Farm Details

Farm name	Upper Assendon Farm
Business name	M J Hunt & Son
Farmer	James Hunt
Address	Upper Assendon Farm, Stonor, Henley-on-Thames, Oxfordshire, RG9 6JH
CPH number	33/227/0030
SBI number	UAF332270030
SFI agreement	SFI 1 — UAF332270030 (ends 31 Mar 2027)
Total farm area	480ha (1,188ac) across 52 RPA parcels
Soil types	Predominantly shallow calcareous soils over chalk; clay-with-flints caps on higher ground; alluvial soils in valley bottoms
NVZ	Whole farm in Nitrate Vulnerable Zone (NVZ)
Plan prepared by	James Hunt (FACTS qualified)
Date prepared	April 2026

2. Purpose of This Plan

This Soil Management Plan has been prepared to meet the requirements of SFI Action SAM1 (Assess and manage soil, produce a written soil management plan) and to demonstrate compliance with SAI Global farm assurance standards for the arable enterprise at Upper Assendon Farm.

The plan sets out how soils across the farm will be assessed, protected, and improved to maintain their long-term productive capacity and environmental function. It covers soil health monitoring, nutrient management, organic matter, compaction management, erosion risk, and cover cropping.

3. Soil Assessment

3.1 Soil Types

The farm sits in the Stonor Valley in the Chiltern Hills, Oxfordshire. Three main soil types are present:

Soil type	Location	Texture	Characteristics
Shallow chalk rendzina	Valley sides, most arable fields	Silty clay loam over chalk	Free-draining, low organic matter, responsive to inputs
Clay-with-flints	Higher ground (Maidensgrove, Stone Hill)	Heavy clay	Slow to warm, compaction risk, good moisture retention
Alluvial/meadow	Valley bottom (The Warren, grassland)	Sandy loam / loam	Higher OM, some flooding risk in winter

3.2 Soil Testing

A comprehensive soil sampling programme was completed in June 2024 by ADAS, covering all 52 parcels. Samples were taken at 0-15cm and 15-30cm depths on a 1ha grid.

Parameter	Target	Farm average	Range	Status
pH	6.5–7.0 (arable)	7.1	6.4–7.8	Good — chalk influence
Phosphorus (P)	Index 2	Index 2	Index 1–3	Satisfactory
Potassium (K)	Index 2	Index 2	Index 1–3	Satisfactory
Magnesium (Mg)	Index 2	Index 2	Index 1–3	Satisfactory
Organic matter (%)	>3.5%	2.8%	1.9–4.2%	Below target — improvement focus
Soil N min (kg/ha)	Variable	45	30–72	Normal range

Soil tests to be repeated on a 5-year rolling cycle. Next full survey: June 2029. Targeted re-sampling of low OM fields: 2026.

3.3 Soil Structure Assessment

Visual Soil Assessment (VSA) was carried out on representative fields in autumn 2025 using the AHDB VSA scorecard methodology. Results:

Field	VSA score	Rating	Notes
Long Ground	24/36	Good	Some surface capping on

Field	VSA score	Rating	Notes
			headlands
Home Piece	22/36	Good	
Stone Hill	18/36	Moderate	Heavy clay — some compaction at 30cm
Bix Field	26/36	Good	Best structure on farm
Lambridge	20/36	Good	
Maidensgrove	16/36	Moderate	Clay-with-flints — priority for deep loosening

4. Soil Health Objectives

The following objectives have been set for the five-year period 2026–2030:

- Increase whole-farm average soil organic matter from 2.8% to 3.5%
- Eliminate soil compaction layers identified in Stone Hill and Maidensgrove fields
- Reduce surface capping on headlands through cover cropping and traffic management
- Maintain P and K indices at 2 across all fields
- Maintain pH above 6.5 using chalk/lime applications where required
- Achieve 100% cover crop or living mulch establishment on all arable fields following cereals

5. Compaction Risk and Management

Soil compaction is the primary structural concern on the farm, particularly on the heavier clay-with-flints soils. The following management practices are in place:

5.1 Preventing Compaction

- All field operations avoided when soil moisture is above field capacity (assessed by kick/probe test before entry)
- Controlled traffic farming (CTF) lines established on Long Ground and Home Piece — machinery confined to fixed wheelings
- Tyre pressures managed — sprayer and drill tyres reduced to minimum when field conditions allow
- Muck/slurry spreading restricted to firm ground conditions or via umbilical where possible
- Minimum tillage approach adopted where possible to protect structure

5.2 Remediating Compaction

- Stone Hill: deep-loosening subsoiling planned for autumn 2026 following harvest — target depth 45cm to break pan
- Maidensgrove: subsoiling with Sumo Trio scheduled autumn 2026, followed by cover crop over winter

- Headland tracking: GPS guidance used to maintain consistent wheelings and minimise area affected

6. Organic Matter Management

Organic matter (OM) is below the target level of 3.5% on most arable fields. The following measures are in place to build OM over time:

6.1 Straw Management

Straw is incorporated on fields identified as low OM (below 2.5%). All other straw is baled and used for livestock bedding, with the resulting FYM returned to land.

6.2 FYM and Slurry

Farm-yard manure from the beef enterprise is spread on arable fields on a rotational basis. FYM is applied at approximately 25t/ha. Slurry is applied to grassland and some arable fields in spring, outside the NVZ closed period. All applications are recorded in the fertiliser records.

6.3 Cover Crops

Multi-species cover crops are established following early-harvested crops (oilseed rape, winter barley) as part of SFI SAM2 actions. Cover crop mixes include:

- Following OSR: radish, phacelia, linseed, buckwheat — sown August
- Following winter barley: phacelia, clover, vetch, linseed — sown August
- Cover crops terminated in February by rolling/herbicide to allow seedbed preparation

6.4 Green Manures and Herbal Leys

Fields in the SFI SAM3 herbal ley option include mixtures of grasses, legumes and herbs to build OM and break arable rotations. Current herbal ley areas are shown in the field records.

7. Nutrient Management

A Nutrient Management Plan (NMP) was produced by ADAS in February 2025 and is reviewed annually. The NMP is based on RB209 guidance and takes into account soil test results, crop requirements, and organic manure inputs.

7.1 Nitrogen

All fields are in an NVZ. The farm N limit is 250kg N/ha/yr for grassland and 170kg N/ha/yr for arable crops. Actual N applications are within these limits. N applications are split to reduce leaching risk — typically two to three applications per crop.

Nitrogen applications are timed based on soil temperature (>5°C), crop growth stage, and weather forecast. No N is applied to waterlogged or frozen ground.

7.2 Phosphorus and Potassium

P and K applications are based on soil index and crop off-take. Compound fertiliser is used where P and K are required alongside N. Applications are recorded in the fertiliser records in Farm Hub.

7.3 Sulphur

Sulphur is applied as YaraBela Extran (NS 26+14) at 80kg/ha on wheat fields showing marginal S levels. SAP testing is used to confirm requirement before application.

7.4 Lime

pH is monitored through the soil sampling programme. Ground limestone is applied where pH falls below 6.5 on arable land. The farm is on chalk and pH tends to be high — the risk is localised acidification in old ley fields. Ground chalk is applied if required.

8. Erosion Risk Assessment

Soil erosion risk is low to moderate on the farm. The main risk factors are:

- Steep slopes on valley-side fields (Stone Hill, Maidensgrove) — risk of surface run-off following heavy rain
- Tramline run-off after prolonged rain
- Bare soils in autumn/winter where OSR fails

Mitigation measures in place:

- 6-metre uncropped buffer strips alongside all watercourses — enrolled in SFI agreement
- Cover crops on early-harvested fields to maintain ground cover over winter
- Cross-slope tramlines on steeper fields where practical
- Beetle banks on Long Ground and Home Piece providing additional run-off protection
- Grass margins on field boundaries maintain structure and intercept run-off

9. Field-by-Field Summary

Field	Area (ha)	Soil type	OM (%)	Priority issue	Action 2026
Long Ground	9.8	Chalk rendzina	2.6	OM building	Straw incorporation + cover crop
Home Piece	6.2	Chalk rendzina	2.9	Headland capping	CTF + reduced passes
Stone Hill	8.9	Clay-with-flints	3.1	Subsoil compaction	Subsoil autumn 2026
Bix Field	12.3	Chalk rendzina	2.4	Low OM	FYM + cover crop OSR
Lambridge	7.6	Chalk rendzina	2.7	Routine maintenance	Continue NMP
Maidensgrove	7.6	Clay-with-flints	3.8	Compaction	Subsoil + herbal ley
Middle Ground	10.1	Chalk rendzina	2.5	OM building	Spring barley + cover

Field	Area (ha)	Soil type	OM (%)	Priority issue	Action 2026
The Warren	9.4	Alluvial loam	4.2	None — best field	Maintain grassland

10. Monitoring and Review

Activity	Method	Frequency	Responsible
Soil sampling (P, K, pH, OM)	ADAS / commercial lab	Every 5 years	James Hunt
Visual Soil Assessment (VSA)	AHDB scorecard — spade assessment	Annual (autumn)	James Hunt
N min soil test	Laboratory analysis	Annual (Feb)	ADAS / James Hunt
Cover crop establishment	Field inspection	Each establishment	James Hunt
Plan review	Update this document	Annual (April)	James Hunt
Fertiliser records	Farm Hub — Compliance section	After each application	James Hunt / Charlie Hunt

This plan will be reviewed annually in April, or sooner if there are significant changes to the farm (new land, major weather events, change of crops). Updated copies will be stored in Farm Hub and in the farm office.

11. Declaration

I confirm that this Soil Management Plan is accurate and that the practices described are being followed on Upper Assendon Farm.

Name: James Hunt

Position: Farm Owner / Operator

Date: April 2026

Signature: _____